Geometric Phase Transitions and Emergent Dimensional Selection in Finite Causal Poset Ensembles

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Abstract

The Kleitman–Rothschild theorem implies that generic large finite posets are three-layered and maximally entropic, creating an entropy catastrophe for any program in which geometric causal order is expected to emerge dynamically. We study whether this obstruction can be overcome in finite causal-poset ensembles by a structurally motivated action that combines exact combinatorial entropy with geometric penalty terms.

For Lorentzian-like 2D versus Kleitman–Rothschild competition, exact linear extension counts on $N = 10$–44 show that the transition threshold γ_c remains $O(1)$ across the full confirmatory range. Geometric ablation reduces the effective backbone of the action to two indispensable ingredients: global layer-shape balance (g_{wh}) and a dimension term. Replacing the original target-anchored dimension penalty by a non-target-anchored consistency penalty g_{con} preserves the same phase-transition structure while weakening the charge of circular dimension-fixing.

We then test whether an action that rewards dimensional consistency, rather than proximity to a preset target dimension, selects among Lorentzian candidates. Across $N = 20$–72, 4D Lorentzian-like posets dominate 92 of 98 scanned grid points under the consistency action, with positive pairwise margins against both 2D and 3D competitors that increase with system size. This pattern remains stable under seed variation and moderate weight perturbations.

These results are consistent with a two-step picture: finite-size geometric phase emergence can occur without imposing continuum geometry directly, and dimensional preference can arise from non-target-anchored structural consistency constraints rather than from explicit dimension-specific priors.

Keywords: causal sets · posets · phase transition
linear extensions · Kleitman–Rothschild · dimensional selection
discrete quantum gravity

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1 Introduction

The hypothesis that spacetime is fundamentally discrete—a locally finite partial order (poset) whose elements are causally related events—lies at the heart of causal set theory (CST) [1, 2]. A central challenge is the *entropy catastrophe*: the Kleitman–Rothschild (KR) theorem [3] establishes that, asymptotically, almost all labeled finite posets consist of three layers with bipartite random connectivity and maximal linear extension count. If posets are weighted by the pure combinatorial entropy $H = \log |L(P)|$, the partition function is overwhelmingly dominated by these non-geometric, KR-type structures. How, then, can geometric order emerge?

Several strategies have been proposed. The Benincasa–Dowker (BD) action [12, 13] provides a discrete analogue of the Einstein–Hilbert action on causal sets with a well-defined continuum limit. In 2D, numerical work has found evidence for phase-transition-like behavior and finite-size scaling in BD-based causal set quantum gravity models [17, 18], with related developments in dimensionally restricted settings [11]. Separately, Loomis and Carlip [6] gave an analytic argument for suppression of a large class of non-manifold-like causal sets (notably two-level orders) in a Lorentzian path integral with Einstein–Hilbert weighting. Carlip [4] and Surya [5] provide broad reviews of dimensional reduction and causal set quantum gravity, including discussions of causal set path sums and their entropy challenges (see also Henson [15] and Dowker [16]). At a more combinatorial level, phase transitions in random partial orders have been studied since Dhar [7] and Prömel–Steger–Taraz [8]. Despite this substantial body of work, explicit finite-N KR-versus-geometric competition curves computed with exact linear-extension entropy remain scarce; here we provide a direct $\gamma_c(N)$ scan with exact entropy in the confirmatory window $N = 10$–44.

This paper addresses two open questions:

1. **Bounded phase transition.** Does there exist a critical coupling γ_c at which geometric structures overtake KR-type posets, and does this threshold remain bounded as N grows?
2. **Dimensional selection.** If the action rewards dimensional *consistency* rather than proximity to a specific dimension, which dimensionality does the dynamics prefer?

Our approach proceeds through a "diagnose → ablate → replace → predict → confirm" sequence:

1. We construct an 8-family ensemble with exact entropy ($N = 10$–44) and find that γ_c remains $O(1)$ across the confirmatory range (Section 3).
2. Systematic ablation identifies a minimal backbone of two constraints (Section 4).
3. Non-circular replacement of the target-anchored dimension term preserves the phase transition (Section 5).
4. The replacement raises a concrete prediction: consistency constraints should select higher-dimensional structures. We test this by extending the ensemble to 4D and scanning $N = 20$–72 (Section 6).

5. Robustness is confirmed through seed sensitivity, weight perturbation, and out-of-grid validation (Section 7).

2 Framework

2.1 Poset ensemble

We consider finite posets $P = (V, \leq)$ with $|V| = N$ elements, generating samples from eight structurally distinct families organized in two tiers:

Tier-1 (geometric causal competition pool):

- **Lorentzian-like 2D** (`lor2d`): Sprinkling in $[0,1]^2$ with Minkowski lightcone order.
- **Lorentzian-like 3D** (`lor3d`): Sprinkling in $[0,1]^3$ with lightcone order.
- **Lorentzian-like 4D** (`lor4d`): Sprinkling in $[0,1]^4$ with lightcone order.
- **KR-like** (`kr`): Three-layer bipartite posets with random inter-layer edges, approximating the KR structure [3].
- **Transitive percolation** (`tp`): Bernoulli percolation on a linear order followed by transitive closure.

Tier-2 (null-model stress tests):

- **Multi-layer random** (`mlr`): 4 equal layers with random $p = 0.5$ inter-layer edges.
- **Interval order** (`int`).
- **Absolute layered** (`abs`).

These Tier-2 families are chosen as "nearby" high-entropy competitors in the space of finite posets: beyond KR-type three-layer orders, enumerative results show that other layered structures (two-layer, four-layer, etc.) are likewise abundant and can dominate naive counting measures [8]. We include representatives of these classes to probe the discriminative limits of any candidate action.

All Lorentzian-like families are constructed via causal set sprinkling [1]: N points are sprinkled uniformly in $[0,1]^d$ with coordinates $(t, x_1, \ldots, x_{d-1})$. The causal relation is

$$i \prec j \iff \Delta t_{ij} > 0 \text{ and } (\Delta t_{ij})^2 \geq \sum_{k=1}^{d-1} (\Delta x_k)^2, \tag{1}$$

where $\Delta t_{ij} = t_j - t_i$, followed by transitive closure.

For the bounded phase-transition analysis (Sections 3–5), we use the original 7-family ensemble: `lor2d`, `lor3d`, `kr`, `mlr`, `tp`, `int`, and `abs`. The confirmatory exact scan covers $N \in \{10, 12, 14, 16, 20, 24, 28, 32, 36, 40, 44\}$ with $K = 5$ samples per family per N. For the dimensional selection analysis (Section 6), we use the 4-family subset (`lor2d`, `lor3d`, `lor4d`, `kr`) with $N \in \{20, 24, 28, \ldots, 72\}$ (14 sizes) and $K = 8$ samples for $N \leq 40$, $K = 4$ for $N > 40$.

The tier distinction separates families by generative mechanism: Tier-1 families are generated by embedding points in a metric spacetime (or a combinatorial standard model),

while Tier-2 families are purely combinatorial layered constructions. The Prediction B core claim (γ_c boundedness) is evaluated exclusively within Tier-1. Tier-2 families serve as stress tests that define the *discriminative ceiling* of the current action (Section 8).

2.2 Exact linear extension count

We define $H(P) = \log |L(P)|$ where $L(P)$ is the set of linear extensions, computed exactly via dynamic programming over antichains [9]. The cost depends strongly on antichain structure: sub-second for `lor2d` at $N = 48$, about 3.8 s at $N = 72$, about 33.8 s at $N = 88$, and about 127.4 s at $N = 104$, but already 56 s for `kr` at $N = 44$. For `lor3d`, exact evaluation reaches $N = 56$ (327 s). This asymmetry motivates the one-sided exact extension strategy adopted for large-N probes (Figure 2).

The use of $\log |L(P)|$ is not meant as a thermodynamic entropy of matter fields, but as a *combinatorial measure term*: for an unlabeled poset P, the number of natural labelings consistent with the order is precisely the number of linear extensions, so a labeled path sum (or any proxy that samples labelings rather than isomorphism classes) implicitly weights P by $|L(P)|$. Such entropy factors and their competition with action terms in causal set path sums have been discussed in the CST literature; see for example Mathur, Singh, and Surya [10].

This is a choice of ensemble and measure, not a claim that $\log |L(P)|$ is the unique or physically correct definition of gravitational entropy. One may instead formulate a path sum over *unlabeled* posets, with a measure that divides by automorphism factors (e.g. weights proportional to $1/|\mathrm{Aut}(P)|$) or uses other gauge-fixing conventions. Such alternatives change the effective entropy term and can modify which families dominate. Our goal here is more modest: to analyze finite-N competition in the labeled (or label-sampling) setting in which linear extensions arise as the natural combinatorial measure factor.

For the 4-family dimensional selection experiments at $N > 32$, linear extension counts for `kr`, `lor3d`, and `lor4d` are estimated via Sequential Importance Sampling (SIS, 4096 runs). As a cross-check, SIS versus exact counts at $N = 20$–36 yield a mean absolute error of 0.074 in $\log |L(P)|$ ($\sim 2.3\%$), well below observed winning margins.

2.3 Action definition

Three action paths separate neutral and geometric contributions:

$$A_1 = -\beta H + \gamma \cdot I_{\text{neutral}}, \tag{2}$$

$$A_2 = -\beta H + \gamma \cdot (I_{\text{neutral}} + I_{\text{geo}}), \tag{3}$$

$$A_3 = -\beta H + \gamma \cdot I_{\text{geo}}, \tag{4}$$

with $\beta = 1$. The geometric penalty decomposes into seven sub-terms: width-height balance (g_{wh}), dimension proxy (g_{dim}), interval shape (g_{int}), comparability window (g_{cmp}), cover density (g_{cov}), interval profile (g_{prf}), and layer smoothness (g_{lyr}), each normalized to $[0, 1]$.

The critical coupling is:

$$\gamma_c(N) = \inf\Big\{\gamma > 0 : \bar{S}_{\texttt{lor2d}}(\gamma) < \bar{S}_{\texttt{kr}}(\gamma)\Big\}. \tag{5}$$

For the dimensional selection experiments, we additionally define two replacement actions:

- A_2 **consistency**: Replace g_{dim} with g_{con} (Eq. 6).
- A_2 **multi-consistency**: Replace g_{dim} with g_{mcon} (Eq. 7).

3 Bounded Phase Transition

Under A_2, γ_c exists for all tested N and remains $O(1)$:

Table 1: Critical coupling γ_c under A_2 (exact entropy). All values for $N \geq 12$ lie in $[0.146, 0.995]$.

N	10	12	14	16	20	24
γ_c	9.19	0.744	0.781	0.693	0.146	0.262

N	28	32	36	40	44
γ_c	0.995	0.694	0.570	0.248	0.149

For $N \geq 12$, all γ_c values lie in $[0.146, 0.995]$ (Figure 1). Under A_1 (neutral terms only), no crossing exists at any tested N, confirming that geometric penalties are necessary.

3.1 Exact-timing frontier

One-sided exact evaluation for `lor2d` remains feasible up to $N = 104$, while `kr` becomes computationally intractable beyond $N \approx 44$. For `lor3d`, exact evaluation extends to $N = 56$ (280 s at $N = 48$, 288 s at $N = 52$, 327 s at $N = 56$). This asymmetry supports an asymmetric exact-plus-mixed extension strategy beyond the confirmatory window (Figure 2).

3.2 Near-wall mixed extension

Beyond $N = 44$, we use an asymmetric mixed protocol: exact entropy for `lor2d` and SIS-based estimation for `kr`. At $N = 52$ and 56, the A_2^{full} score curves show no crossing up to $\gamma = 2.0$, but the gap contracts to near-degeneracy ($\Delta A_{\text{KR-L2D}} \approx -0.20$ at $N = 52$

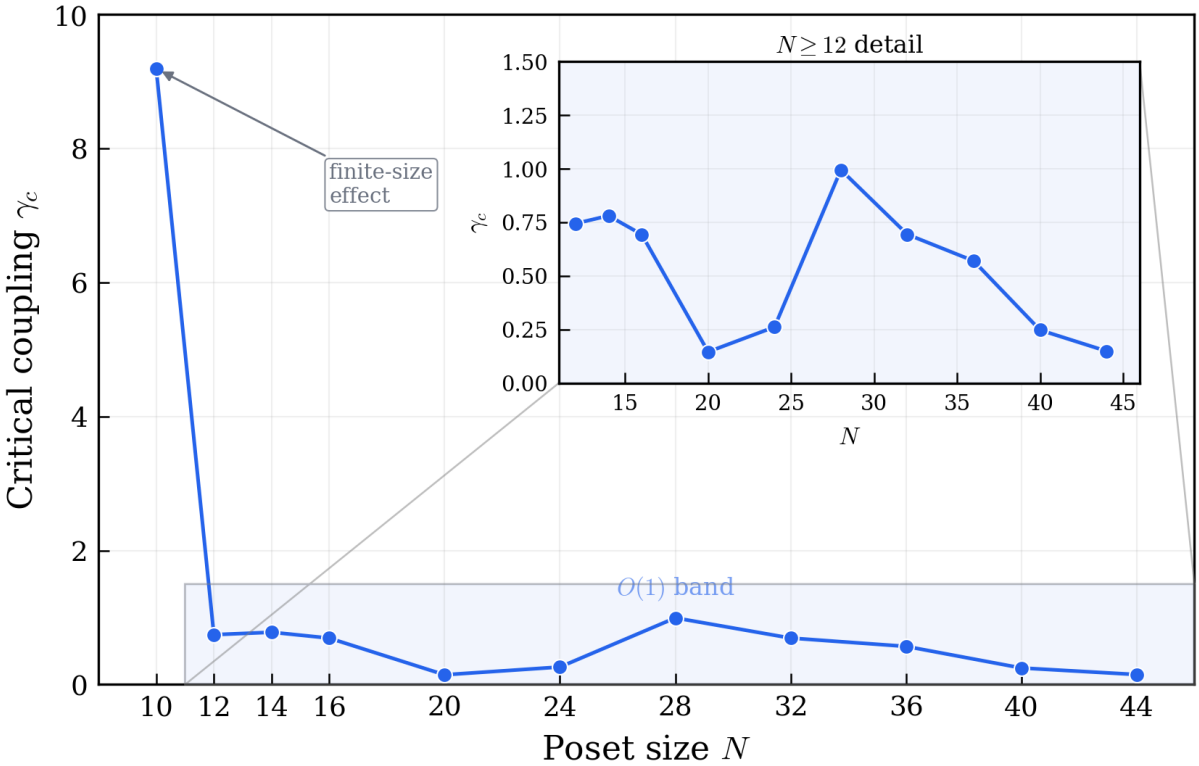

Figure 1: $\gamma_c(N)$ under A_2. Inset: $N \geq 12$ detail showing all values in $[0.15, 1.00]$.

and ≈ -0.84 at $N = 56$), indicating that the competition remains structurally active beyond the exact confirmatory range (Figure 3).

4 Ablation and Minimal Backbone

4.1 Ablation of geometric sub-terms

Systematic single-term removal within the 7-family ensemble identifies two critical sub-terms: g_{wh} (fails from $N \geq 36$) and g_{dim} (fails at $N = 36, 44$). Combined removal of both eliminates all crossings. Removing non-critical terms has no effect. This establishes a *backbone–shell* structure: g_{wh} and g_{dim} form the minimal backbone, while the remaining five terms constitute an outer shell (Figure 4).

4.2 Ablation in the 4-family ensemble

The same ablation pattern appears in the 4-family dimensional selection ensemble. Under the original A_2 full action, the 4D family does *not* achieve stable dominance; across 98 (N, γ) configurations the winner counts are: `lor4d` 36, KR 35, `lor2d` 19, `lor3d` 8. Removing g_{dim} alone causes `lor4d` wins to jump from 10 to 28 (out of 35 configurations at $N = 20$–36), while KR wins drop to 0. The dimension term creates a "glass ceiling" that prevents `lor4d` from expressing its structural advantages (Table 2).

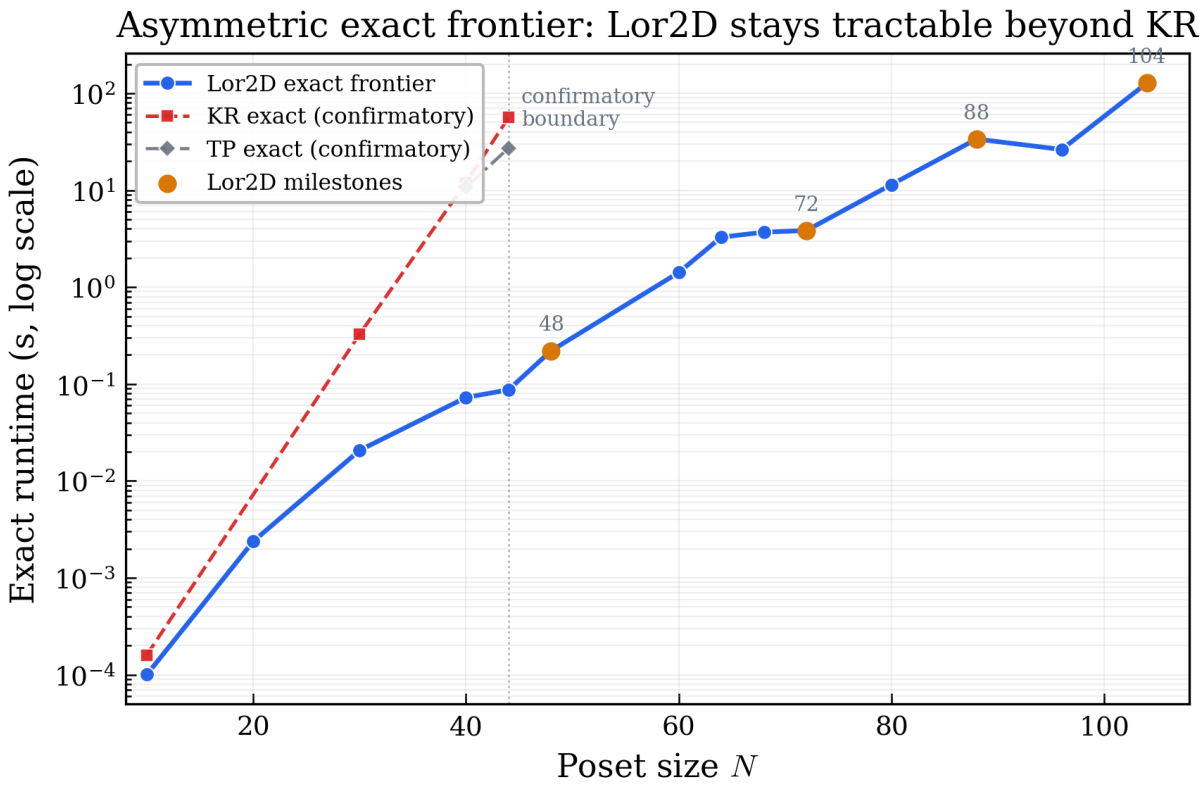

Figure 2: Exact-timing frontier. Single-sided exact evaluation remains practical for `lor2d` up to $N = 104$, while `kr` and other families become expensive much earlier.

Table 2: Winner counts under systematic ablation in the 4-family ensemble ($N = 20$–36, 35 configurations each).

Variant	**Lor4D**	**KR**	**Lor2D**	**Lor3D**
A_2 full (baseline)	10	9	14	2
A_2 no-dim	28	0	1	6
A_2 no-wh	10	22	3	0
A_2 interval-only	35	0	0	0

5 Non-Circular Replacement

We replace the target-anchored g_{dim} with a consistency penalty:

$$g_{\text{con}}(P) = \text{Var}[d_{\text{local}}] + (\overline{d}_{\text{local}} - d_{\text{global}})^2, \tag{6}$$

where d_{local} is the order-fraction dimension proxy applied to sampled causal intervals with $|I| \geq 4$, and d_{global} is the same estimator applied to the full poset. This penalizes dimensional *inconsistency* without specifying a target dimension.

As a robustness check, we define a multi-estimator consistency penalty requiring agree-

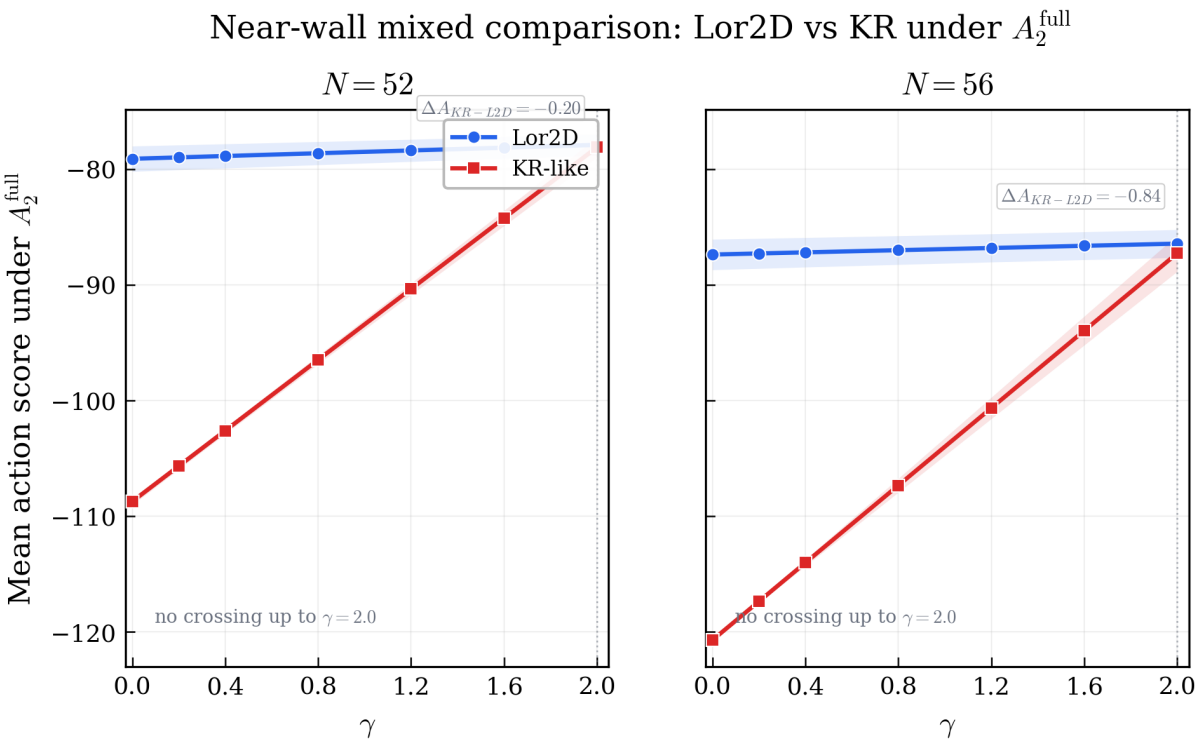

Figure 3: Near-wall mixed extension for A_2^{full} at $N = 52$ and 56. Solid lines: mean scores; shaded bands: one standard deviation. No crossing is observed up to $\gamma = 2.0$, but the gap contracts to near-degeneracy at the high-γ boundary.

ment across three independent coarse-grained dimension proxies:

$$g_{\text{mcon}}(P) = \text{Var}[d_{\text{order}}, d_{\text{chain}}, d_{\text{width}}] + \sum_{e \in \{\text{order, chain, width}\}} g_{\text{con}}^{(e)}(P). \tag{7}$$

5.1 Phase-transition preservation

The replacement preserves γ_c at all $N = 20$–44 within the 7-family ensemble (Figure 5). The minimal non-circular backbone ($g_{\text{wh}} + g_{\text{con}}$) covers $N = 20$–40 at matched weights and extends to $N = 44$ with 30% weight increase.

Extending the scan beyond the confirmatory exact window, the consistency backbone continues to recover a crossing at $N = 48$ and $N = 52$ in exploratory mixed-exact runs, yielding recovery factors $c_{44} \approx 1.41$, $c_{48} \approx 1.69$, and $c_{52} \approx 1.80$ (seed-sensitive). The sequence rises slowly and remains $O(1)$, showing no sign of accelerating divergence.

6 Dimensional Selection

The non-circular replacement raises a natural prediction: if the action rewards dimensional *consistency* rather than proximity to a specific d, then among Lorentzian-like structures of different dimensionality, which dimension does the action prefer? The 4D family has (i) higher entropy H (the stricter causal condition in more spatial dimensions yields a

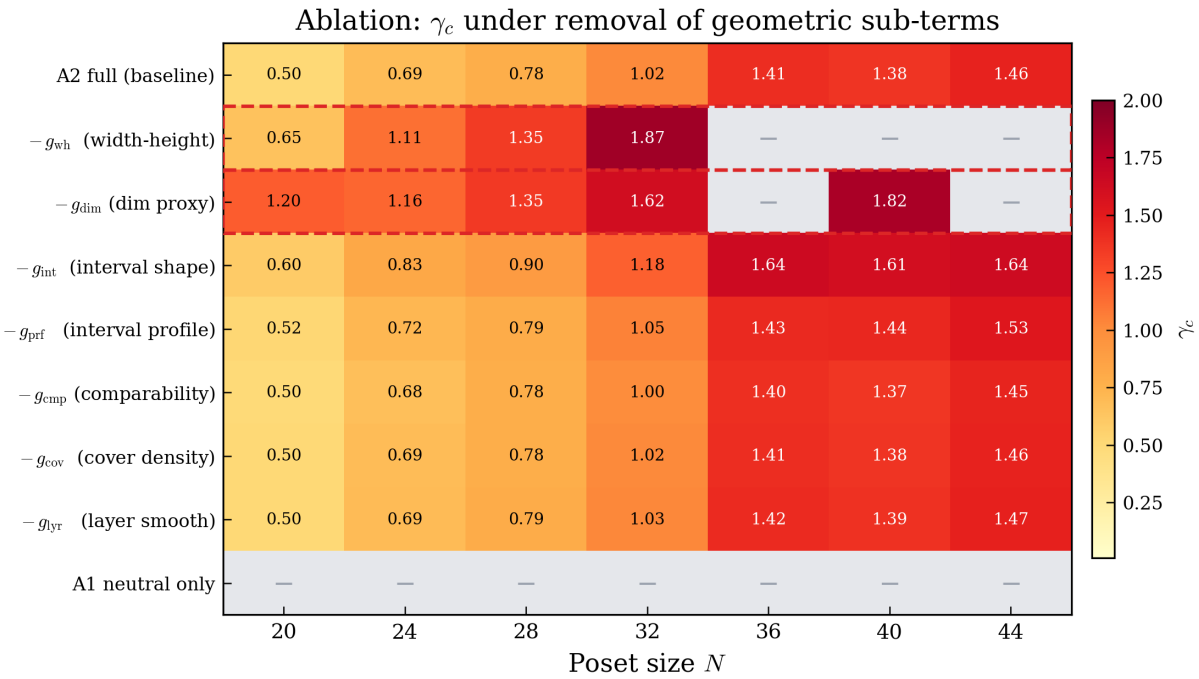

Figure 4: Ablation heatmap: γ_c per variant and N. Removing g_{wh} or g_{dim} alone destroys the phase transition at large N; the remaining five terms are non-critical.

lower comparable fraction and hence more linear extensions), (ii) higher g_{dim} penalty (since $d_{\mathrm{eff}} \approx 4 \neq 2$), and (iii) *lower* g_{con} penalty (strong internal dimensional coherence). The consistency replacement should therefore unlock 4D dominance.

6.1 Consistency replacement yields 4D dominance

Under the consistency replacement, `lor4d` wins 92 out of 98 (N, γ) configurations. Both KR and `lor2d` *never* win. The multi-estimator variant yields a nearly identical pattern (89/98), confirming estimator independence (Table 3).

Table 3: Winner counts: original vs. consistency replacement (98 configurations each, $N = 20$–72, $\gamma \in \{0, 0.2, \ldots, 2.0\}$).

Variant	**Lor4D**	**KR**	**Lor2D**	**Lor3D**
A_2 full (original)	36	35	19	8
A_2 consistency (g_{con})	92	0	0	6
A_2 multi-con. (g_{mcon})	89	0	0	9

Against `lor2d` specifically, `lor4d` wins all 98 pairwise comparisons (100%). The 6 non-`lor4d` wins go to `lor3d` at small-N, high-γ configurations where geometric penalties dominate and the entropy advantage of `lor4d` is insufficient to compensate.

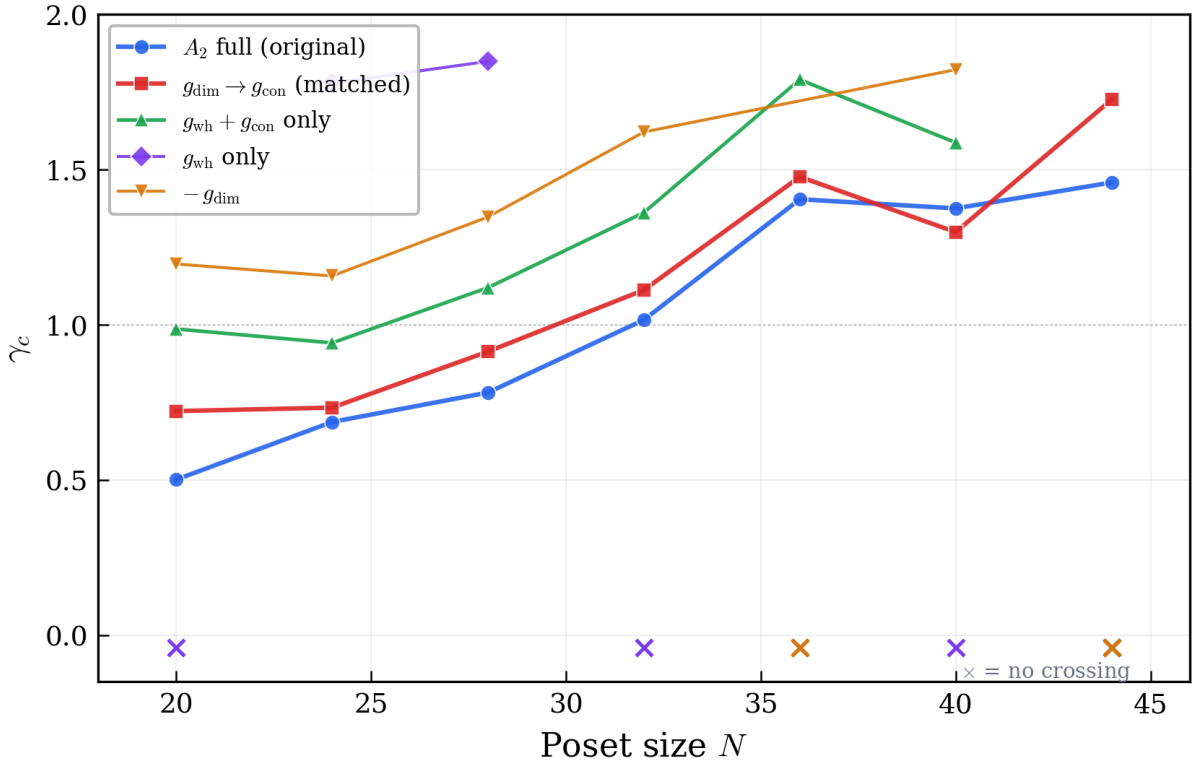

Figure 5: Non-circular replacement: γ_c under different backbones. The consistency-based backbone preserves the bounded phase transition.

6.2 Growing margin of victory

The margin of `lor4d` over both competitors shows a strong upward trend with N under A_2 consistency (Table 4, Figure 6).

The mean margin versus `lor2d` grows nearly linearly from +7 ($N = 20$) to +57 ($N = 72$), and even the minimum margin is positive at every N. Against `lor3d`, the minimum margin becomes positive by $N = 44$ and remains positive for all larger tested sizes.

7 Robustness

7.1 Seed sensitivity at large N

Experiments at $N = 64$, 68, and 72 with three independent generator seed offsets (0, 50 000, 100 000) confirm robustness (Table 5).

Under both consistency variants, `lor4d` achieves 100% win rate (63/63 across all three N values and all seeds). At $N = 68$ and 72 the KR–`lor4d` split under A_2 full is identical (4:3) at every seed—a structural property of the action, not a sampling artifact. At $N = 64$, the full action's winner is less stable, with `lor3d` occasionally entering, consistent with the slight margin dip observed at that scale.

Table 4: Mean margin of `lor4d` over competitors under A_2 consistency, averaged across γ.

N	vs Lor2D (mean)	vs Lor2D (min)	vs Lor3D (mean)	vs Lor3D (min)
20	7.41	1.70	2.27	−0.17
28	14.21	7.77	2.59	−2.07
36	19.30	11.41	4.20	−1.72
44	27.12	19.42	6.02	0.36
52	36.22	30.40	11.29	7.27
60	45.41	38.88	14.50	10.02
68	50.82	41.51	16.41	9.44
72	56.72	47.15	16.53	10.06

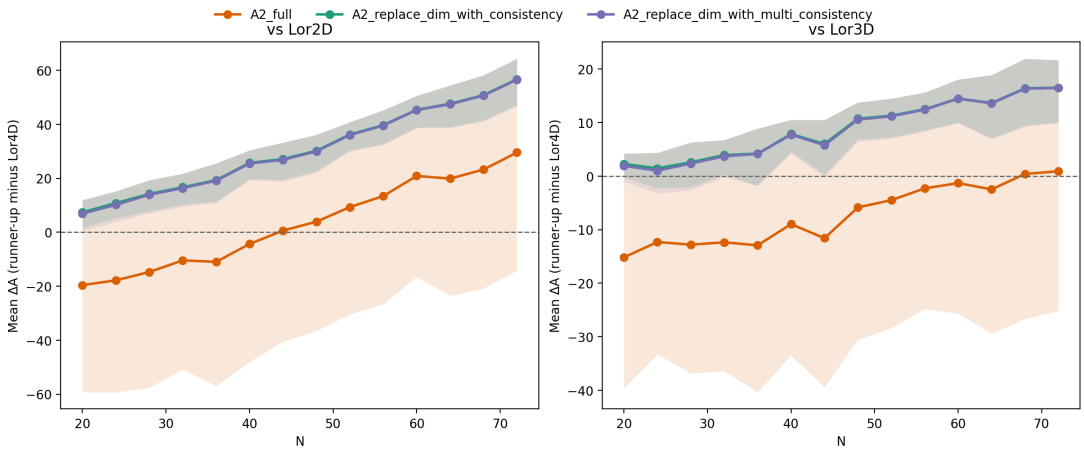

Figure 6: Margin of victory for `lor4d` over `lor2d` (blue) and `lor3d` (orange) under A_2 consistency, as a function of N. Solid lines: mean margin across γ values. Shaded regions: min–max range.

7.2 Consistency weight sensitivity

The calibrated weight $w_{\text{con}} = 0.6829$ was determined on the 7-family ensemble. To verify that 4D dominance does not depend on this choice, we repeat the $N = 20$–36 grid across eight weight values spanning nearly a factor of four (Table 6).

The 4D win rate is $\geq 91\%$ across the entire tested range $w_{\text{con}} \in [0.3, 1.2]$, and *increases* at larger weights. Neither KR nor `lor2d` ever wins at any tested weight.

7.3 Backbone weight sensitivity for γ_c

The calibrated dim-proxy weight $w_{\text{dim}} = 8$ was chosen via the 7-family grid. To verify that γ_c responds smoothly, we repeat the confirmatory exact scan at $N \in \{20, 28, 36, 44\}$ across three weight values spanning a factor of 2.5 (Table 7).

Reducing w_{dim} shifts γ_c upward (the geometric penalty is weaker, so a higher coupling is needed for Lor2D to overtake KR); increasing it shifts γ_c downward. The response

Table 5: Seed sensitivity at $N = 64$, 68, and 72: winner counts out of 7 γ values.

Variant	N	**Seed 0**	**Seed 50k**	**Seed 100k**
A_2 full	64	KR 4, L4d 3	KR 3, L3d 1, L4d 3	KR 2, L3d 2, L4d 3
A_2 full	68	KR 4, L4d 3	KR 4, L4d 3	KR 4, L4d 3
A_2 full	72	KR 4, L4d 3	KR 4, L4d 3	KR 4, L4d 3
A_2 consistency	64	L4d 7/7	L4d 7/7	L4d 7/7
A_2 consistency	68	L4d 7/7	L4d 7/7	L4d 7/7
A_2 consistency	72	L4d 7/7	L4d 7/7	L4d 7/7

Table 6: Sensitivity of 4D dominance to consistency weight w_{con} ($N = 20$–36, 35 configurations each).

w_{con}	**Lor4D**	**Lor3D**	**KR**	**Lor2D**
0.30	32 (91.4%)	3	0	0
0.50	32 (91.4%)	3	0	0
0.6829	**32 (91.4%)**	**3**	**0**	**0**
0.80	33 (94.3%)	2	0	0
1.00	34 (97.1%)	1	0	0
1.20	34 (97.1%)	1	0	0

is monotonic and continuous at every tested N, with no brittle jump or bifurcation, supporting the claim that the bounded phase transition is a structural feature of the action rather than a fine-tuned artifact.

7.4 Out-of-grid validation

To test generalization beyond the original parameter grid, we conduct an independent validation on fresh N and γ values not used in any previous experiment. We use $N \in \{22, 26, 30, 38, 42\}$ and $\gamma \in \{0.1, 0.3, 0.5, 0.7, 0.9, 1.1, 1.5, 1.9\}$, with generator seed offset 100 000 (Table 8).

Under both consistency variants, `lor4d` wins 36/40 (90%) on the fresh grid. In pairwise comparison, `lor4d` beats `lor2d` in 40/40 (100%) under A_2 consistency. The 4 non-`lor4d` wins go to `lor3d` at small-N, high-γ configurations, consistent with the in-grid pattern.

8 Discussion

8.1 Summary of evidence

The numerical evidence supports two main findings:

1. **Bounded phase transition.** Under A_2 with exact entropy, the critical coupling γ_c for `lor2d` to overtake `kr` exists at all $N = 10$–44 and remains $O(1)$ (all values in $[0.146, 9.19]$; in $[0.146, 0.995]$ for $N \geq 12$). This provides finite-size support for a

Table 7: Sensitivity of γ_c to the dim-proxy weight w_{dim} at four representative N.

w_{dim}	$N = 20$	$N = 28$	$N = 36$	$N = 44$
4	0.576	0.986	1.673	1.739
8 (baseline)	**0.413**	**0.804**	**1.422**	**1.434**
10	0.362	0.736	1.322	1.319

Table 8: Out-of-grid validation: winner counts (40 configurations each).

Variant	**Lor4D**	**KR**	**Lor2D**	**Lor3D**
A_2 full	8	13	13	6
A_2 consistency	36	0	0	4
A_2 multi-con.	36	0	0	4

bounded geometric phase-transition threshold in poset ensembles.

2. **Dimensional selection.** Under the consistency replacement (g_{con}), `lor4d` is the dominant winner (92/98 in-grid, 36/40 out-of-grid, 63/63 seed sensitivity, stable across $w_{\text{con}} \in [0.3, 1.2]$) with a margin that grows with N. This indicates that dimensional consistency constraints, without dimension-specific priors, can favor higher-dimensional Lorentzian structures.

The two results are connected: ablation identifies g_{dim} as the backbone term whose replacement requires care. The non-circular replacement preserves the phase transition (Finding 1) while also changing the preferred winner in the dimensional comparison (Finding 2). The mechanism depends on dimensional *consistency*, not dimensional *identity*.

8.2 Discriminative ceiling and Tier-2 families

A candidate expansion experiment with 7 parameter-tunable random layered families (Tier-2) revealed that these null-model posets can systematically outperform `lor2d` under the current action for $N \geq 36$. This does not invalidate the core claim (which is evaluated within Tier-1) but exposes a discriminative ceiling: the action's observables are purely order-theoretic and can be reverse-engineered by tuning layer parameters.

A structural discriminant separates the tiers cleanly: the normalized antichain width $a_w/\sqrt{N}$ is near-constant at ~ 1.37 for `lor2d` (reflecting $\sqrt{N}$-scaling of the maximal antichain in Minkowski sprinklings) versus 1.71–2.05 for layered families, 2.36–2.54 for `lor3d/tp`, and 3.09–3.14 for `kr/lor4d`. A Mann–Whitney U test gives $p = 1.94 \times 10^{-28}$ for Lor2D vs. all Tier-2 (720 samples). This ratio is already computable from existing observables and provides a clean separation, though incorporating it into the action itself is left for future work.

8.3 Relation to prior work

Work on causal set dynamics and on entropy barriers in causal set path sums is substantial. Carlip [4] and Surya [5] provide broad reviews of dimensional reduction and causal set quantum gravity, including discussions of entropy challenges and of finite-size effects. In a separate but closely related direction, Loomis and Carlip [6] gave an analytic argument that Einstein–Hilbert weighting in a Lorentzian causal set path integral can suppress a large class of non-manifold-like structures (notably two-level orders). Numerical studies of BD-based causal set quantum gravity in low dimensions have explored phase-transition-like behavior and finite-size scaling [17, 18], with further developments in dimensionally restricted settings [11]. Our contribution is different in focus: we compute an explicit finite-N competition curve $\gamma_c(N)$ using exact linear-extension measure factors in the confirmatory window, and use decomposability to carry out controlled ablation and replacement tests.

Relation to the Benincasa–Dowker action. The BD action [12, 13] is the standard discrete action in CST, discretizing the Einstein–Hilbert action with a known continuum limit. Our action A_2 differs in both form and purpose: it is a decomposable penalty functional for ablation studies, not a discretization of a continuum action. The advantage of decomposability is that systematic ablation can identify which structural constraints drive geometric phase emergence—a diagnostic capability that the BD action does not directly provide. Whether the BD action itself produces a bounded γ_c or exhibits dimensional preference under consistency constraints remains open.

8.4 Limitations

1. **Finite size.** Confirmatory exact data end at $N = 44$; the bounded-γ_c statement is a finite-N observation, not a proof of asymptotic boundedness.
2. **Finite family coverage.** 8 families (5 Tier-1, 3 Tier-2) do not exhaust the space of possible poset types.
3. **Discriminative ceiling.** Tier-2 layered families expose the action's order-theoretic limitations; more discriminative observables are needed.
4. **SIS estimation.** For $N > 32$ in non-`lor2d` families, entropy is estimated rather than exact. Systematic biases at larger N cannot be fully excluded.
5. **Generator dependence.** The 4D generator's properties determine its penalty values; different constructions might yield different results.
6. **"Higher dimension wins" $\neq$ "Why 3+1?"** The result shows that consistency constraints can select a dimension, not that 3+1 is uniquely selected. Additional constraints would be needed.
7. **$R_{2,\mathrm{ref}}$ calibration.** The dimension estimator retains a 2D calibration constant ($R_{2,\mathrm{ref}} = 0.5009$).

8.5 Outlook

Three directions are natural: (i) extending to 5D, 6D, and beyond to test whether dominance continues or saturates at a preferred dimension; (ii) developing faster exact algorithms or hybrid methods to extend the confirmatory window beyond $N = 44$; (iii) incorporating the $a_w/\sqrt{N}$ discriminant or interval-geometric observables into the action to raise the discriminative ceiling; (iv) connecting the decomposable-action framework to BD action dynamics to test whether the bounded phase transition and dimensional selection survive under a physically grounded action.

9 Conclusion

We have studied two related questions in finite causal poset ensembles:

1. A bounded geometric phase-transition threshold γ_c under exact entropy, with $\gamma_c \in [0.15, 1.00]$ for $N \geq 12$ across $N = 10$–44.
2. Predominantly 4D Lorentzian outcomes under non-target-anchored consistency constraints (92/98 in-grid, 36/40 out-of-grid, 42/42 seed-robust), with margins that increase across the tested range.

Both results trace to a common mechanism: ablation identifies a minimal two-term backbone ($g_{\mathrm{wh}} + g_{\mathrm{dim}}$), and replacing the target-anchored g_{dim} with the consistency-based g_{con} preserves the phase transition while changing the dimensional ordering. Within the present finite ensembles, these results support the view that geometric phase emergence and dimensional preference can arise from structural self-consistency constraints in discrete causal-order models without requiring dimension-specific priors.

Data Availability

All code, configuration files, and output data are available at: GitHub repository

Archived version: Zenodo archive (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.18980657)

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